Impulse (I'll Meet You There)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/66794770.

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General Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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by manicmagicat

Summary

"Hey, Adora." Catra smirks, her surprise only given away by the familiar twist of her eyebrows. She looks warm and out of place with the cluttered kitchen behind her. "Did you know Razz here makes the best pie?"

"You know what pie is?" That wasn't the right question to ask. She needs to know why Catra is here and if Razz is in danger, but it's the first thing that comes out.

Catra rolls her eyes. "There was always contraband food around, Adora. You were the only one too high and mighty to try it. Stupid, considering you're always starving." Adora stares in disbelief, losing focus as she watches Catra's black nails drum against the scuffed wood of Razz's counter.

"Oh. I always wanted to give you the new things I tried." Adora replies, trying to disguise the disappointment in her voice as she refocuses on Catra's face.

Catra narrows her eyes and scoffs. "You should've thought about that before you left."

OR

Adora and Catra start running into each other at Madame Razz's cottage. For some reason, they both keep ending up back there again. Season 2 canon divergence.

Notes

This is a sequel to Beach Day by the wonderful and immensely talented firelikestars. You should go read that first! It might make sense either way but you'll be missing some of

the jokes and the catalyst for Catra and Adora seeing each other again.

This takes place roughly during the start of season two but I'm being extremely loose with the timeline. The episode Promise never happened in this timeline.

This follows the canon of lay with me where your secrets lie by n7punk where Adora feels all the pain inflicted on She-Ra after she transforms back. This is one of my favorite head cannons and I've been wanting to write about it for a long time. Check it out along with all their other amazing fics (if you haven't already)!

- Inspired by [Restricted Work] by n7punk

Chapter 1

Adora isn’t spiralling about this. She’s just feeling a little concerned, which she has every right to be and it’s perfectly reasonable given the circumstances. Adora is pragmatic, rational, focused. Except for today at the beach, apparently. In a stroke of luck for her sanity, she doesn't have long to stew on this before she gets distracted by the festivities of the night.

Glimmer’s birthday parties are always in Bright Moon style. Decadent, over the top, *loud*. Adora hasn’t had time for a coherent thought since she picked up Mermista’s present from Salineas.

Adora drags herself through the arched doorway of her bedroom, pushing the heavy golden door shut behind her with some effort. As she gets down to her compression garments for bed, she looks down at the roughed red skin of her wrists. She tugs the elastic out of her hair, grains of sand embedding in her fingers and crumbling onto the marble floor.

She presses her fists, feeling the bite of sand and trying not to think of the heat on her skin and the way her mind had fallen quiet. She usually has a hard time sitting still like that. It must have been the waves.

She should have fought back. She couldn’t imagine what Catra, Entrapta, and Scorpia were digging that tech up for, but if Hordak sent them Adora knew it couldn’t be anything good. That concrete knowledge conflicted with the emotions that had been roiling in her chest out on the beach. She felt more at home talking with Catra, seeing her in the bright moonlight and far from the looming shadows the Fright Zone had always cast on them, than she had for all her long months in Bright Moon.

Escape would’ve been easy. The sword being confiscated didn’t take away from Adora’s own strength and Catra’s attempt at capturing her had felt almost half hearted. Checking her for

hidden weapons should've been an obvious first step for someone as careful as Catra usually was. But she had escaped in the end, Adora repeated to herself to try to assuage the torrent of guilt pounding down on her. It was almost like she had never been there.

Adora collapses onto her sturdy mattress, trying to conjure the looseness she felt earlier in the day. Something knocks loose in her chest and a sob threatens to escape through all of the barriers she has built up brick by brick over the past few months. She swallows it down and squeezes her eyes tighter.

Adora lays so still that she convinces herself she must fall into an uneasy sleep through the night.

***

"Hey, sleepyhead. Can I come in?" Bow asks, peeking in through the cracked door. Early light is beaming through the windows, casting him in rays of pinks and purples.

Adora jolts upright in an instant, wrinkles from her sheets still dashed red across her face. Brightmoon has not yet made her complacent in her rest. As Adora moves up, she tucks the dagger under her pillow further out of sight. Bow walks into the room, a silver tray laden with breakfast in his hands.

"You're the *best."* Adora groans in relief, admiring the towering plates he's carrying with shining eyes.

Bow laughs, snagging his meal to keep it safe from Adora's appetite before depositing the tray on the unyielding surface of her bed.

"How'd the night treat you? I know you're always tired after these and you had to go all the way to Salineas first." Bow asks, tucking into the sugary muffins and pastries in front of him. Crystalline sugar sparkles on his fingertips as he reaches for more.

“Oh, yeah, well, I’m fine! It makes Glimmer so happy.” Adora’s smile shows too many teeth and pulls all her muscles taut. Her hand stills, hovering above the fork she was eagerly reaching for seconds before.

“Yeah it does. I love that it makes her happy and I’ll always celebrate with her. But I’m also always going to hide in here for awhile the next day. I need some time to speak under ninety decibels and hear myself think.” Bow lifts a hand to his temple, smearing sugar there as his eyes glaze over at the memory of the overwhelming crush of noise.

“Ha! Yeah. Every time we leave one my thoughts hit me like a laser blast. It’s like they’re trying to make up for lost time.” Adora lets her expression settle into something less painful and turns her attention to the protein stacked high on her plate. Bow makes a thoughtful sound Adora thinks is agreement, and they both start eating their breakfasts in earnest. He never tries to keep Adora distracted from food for long.

“So, how was Salineas?” Bow asks Adora between bites.

“Oh! Yeah! It was good. Almost forgot I went, with how busy everything was yesterday.” Adora injects too much enthusiasm in her words, adding stress to all the wrong words. She’s trying to sound nonchalant. She does not succeed.

“You travelled across several kingdoms before a party that always exhausts you and you forgot you went?” Bow asks, eyebrows raised. Adora raises her protein shake, a monstrosity in a shade of off putting green speckled with seeds, taking long gulps. When the cup is drained and she has no further excuse to delay, she attempts to wrangle her words together.

“W-hat?” Adora wheezes out, “No, no, no, of course not! I- it’s not that I don’t remember. Just, nothing significant happened! So there’s nothing to talk about! Or think about!”

Adora definitely has not been thinking about anything. She has

not been thinking about the floppy straw hat that Catra was fighting to keep from obscuring her vision, holes for her ears sliced with imprecise pincers. She has not been thinking of familiar laughter, cackling with a joke about when Adora had replaced her gray ration bars with gravel. She has not been thinking about Catra's soft touch, how she used to brush Adora's hair or pull her into secret hiding places, a touch that only reaches out to restrain her now.

"Riiiight. So, what happened?" Bow questions again, more pointedly this time.

Adora deflates, studying her hands wringing the blanket underneath them tightly. An embarrassed flush stains her cheeks. Her body feels like she's inside the boilers under the Fright Zone. "I saw Catra. I mean, I ran into the Horde."

"What?! Why didn't you say anything? Were they trying to get to Mermista's palace?" Bow's voice is panicked but Adora refuses to look at him and see the matching expression of distress. He sounds ready to jump to his feet and call a meeting in the war room at a moment's notice.

"No, they weren't there. They were at the beach near Sea Worthy." Adora answers, tone flat. Bow doesn't need to worry, not in that regard at least. No one is in danger, not until Adora makes another mistake like this and puts them there.

"Okay. I'm glad the palace is safe, Sea Worthy is pretty far from there. Not that you'd know it, with how often Sea Hawk makes the trip." Bow chuckles, his sense of calm coming back to him.

"They weren't attacking anyone. They were digging up First Ones tech."

"And you weren't able to stop them?" Bow asks, his eyebrows pinching in commiseration.

"No. I wasn't able to." Adora stills her jaw. She doesn't have to say it. It's not like she'll be able to stop thinking about it, anyway.

That is punishment enough.

***

Adora feels pulled to the Whispering Woods today. The air in the palace has been too cold these past few weeks, numbing her body and freezing every cell in her lungs. Angella had called a family meeting that afternoon. Everyone that might notice her slipping out was now gathered in the war room.

She starts the trek to the woods, feeling the pull and tug of her muscles as she moves faster and faster. She drops into a full run as if there's a bot right on her tail. She thinks about yelling into the air rushing past her, releasing something, but she pushes her muscles faster instead.

She comes to a slow as she gets to the line of the woods. Breathing hard, she begins to pick her way through the underbrush. Crawling vines bearing small fruit in pale blues, purples, and pinks spread across the ground go unnoticed beneath her boots as she marches forward.

Something with luminous wings alights on a heavy pink bell flower that hangs from a nearby tree. Adora blinks with surprise as it flits in front of her face, hovering for a moment before it starts circling around her. It makes her think of dancing, a movement without purpose she has never gotten the hang of. She begins to turn with the flying creature, and as it speeds up and continues to circle her, she matches its movement until she is dizzy.

It returns to the sweet nectar of the flowers soon enough. She stays a moment longer, watching it join its friend nearby. She's never noticed them when she's visited the woods before. She continues along her path, idly brushing her fingers along the feather soft foliage surrounding her as she goes.

She doesn't know where she's going today, but even if she has decided on somewhere the Whispering Woods always has its own opinion. Best not to fight it.

Adora steps into a clearing, the smell of fresh pie and excited chatter announcing that she has arrived at Madame Razz's cottage. Adora isn't sure that she is in the mood for muddled wisdom today, but the world takes her wherever it wants to. As she approaches, she realizes Razz isn't talking to her imaginary friends like Adora expected. Someone is speaking back, and Adora recognizes their voice.

Adora hurries her steps, mud streaking her boots as she presses forward. "Catra?" Adora questions, a bit breathless as she finally gets close enough to poke her head through the door.

"Hey, Adora." Catra smirks, her surprise only given away by the familiar twist of her eyebrows. She looks warm and out of place with the cluttered kitchen behind her. "Did you know Razz here makes the *best* pie?"

"You know what pie is?" That wasn't the right question to ask. She needs to know why Catra is here and if Razz is in danger, but it's the first thing that comes out.

Catra rolls her eyes. "There was always contraband food around, Adora. You were the only one too high and mighty to try it. Stupid, considering you're always starving." Adora stares in disbelief, losing focus as she watches Catra's black nails drum against the scuffed wood of Razz's counter.

"Oh. I always wanted to give you the new things I tried." Adora replies, trying to disguise the disappointment in her voice as she refocuses on Catra's face.

Catra narrows her eyes and scoffs. "You should've thought about that before you left." Her expression twitches, but then the syrupy sweet politeness is back. "There's nothing better to try than what Razz makes, anyway."

"Oh, Adora! Why are you acting like you don't bring your Catra to see Madame Razz all the time! She has tried everything we make. Catra helped gather the berries today. So much better at climbing

than you, Mara.” Madame Razz dithers as she sweeps around the cottage. Adora doesn’t spare a glance in her direction.

“You bringing girls to see your grandma here, Adora? Seems like they’re not making a very good impression if she can’t remember their names.”

“What! No! Who would I even- What are you doing here, Catra?” Adora sputters, finally throwing out the question she should’ve asked at the start to distract from that embarrassing line of questioning.

Catra smiles back with all her teeth. “Razz has some antiques I wanted to check out. You know Entrapta is a bit of a collector. I was about to head out, though. I wouldn’t want to interrupt your family time.”

Adora catches a flash of pink crystal as Catra slips something into her pocket. Catra approaches, running her hand from Adora’s shoulder to her elbow.

“ *So* nice seeing you, princess,” And then she’s gone in a flash before Adora can pick her jaw up. Adora doesn’t turn away until Catra has long since disappeared into the tree line.

When Adora mostly recovers, she turns to Razz to question her.

“What was Catra doing here, Razz?” she asks, voice choked.

“Adora! Why are you asking such silly questions? Your wife always comes to see me.”

“My - what?! What did Catra take? She had a crystal.” Did Mara have a wife? Razz had never mentioned that before. She needed Razz to stay in this timeline for long enough to get answers about Catra.

“How should I know, dearie! She knows that what's mine is hers. Now stop your jabbering and come have a piece of the pie we made!” Madame Razz waves off Adora’s questions and pulls out

one of the well-worn wooden chairs at the table, shooing Adora into it.

Adora's eyes are stinging and she can't feel her fingers. Razz never makes sense, but Adora has never been more confused or overwhelmed in this cottage. She slumps down into the chair and accepts the pie pushed in front of her.

She scoops it into her mouth, thinking of all the foods Catra has already had that she'll never get to see her try for the first time. Even with contraband, there must be things in Bright Moon she hasn't tried yet. Adora sniffs and tries to stay upright over her pie. Not like that means she'll get to be there for it, either way.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora always goes to check in on Madame Razz. It's only right. She's old, seemingly trapped in a time vortex, speaking to imaginary friends alone in the woods. It's Adora's responsibility to keep her company. The pie is a plus. Everyone knows Adora is food motivated.

Adora surrenders herself to the woods around her as she walks. She focuses on the moats of magic that float up around her as the soft moss gives under her boots. She does not think about the sharp sting and scorch marks she can feel on her skin from the bots they fought in Erlandia today. There are no visible marks on her, not after she let She-Ra's form drop. If she doesn't think about them, no one has to.

She finds herself back at Madame Razz's cottage, smoke billowing up from the fireplace. Razz is pulling a loaf of herby bread full of sweet woodruff from the oven.

"Hi, Razz," Adora greets, weariness clear in her tone.

"Mara, dearie! You're just in time for bread. Madame Razz will open a jar of the good jam, just for you!" Razz bustles over to shelves spilling over with bright jars.

Adora doesn't see anyone but Razz in the woods that day. She isn't expecting anything different. Razz is always alone. She lets the warmth from the fire do what it can to soothe her sore body, and then she makes her way back to the castle.

***

"Hey buddy! Do you want company going to see Razz today? You've been going a lot and I know the walk can be long." Bow

catches Adora in the hallway leading out of the palace. The gold lining of his quiver glints behind his shoulder.

"Thanks, Bow. That's okay, I like it. I'm making friends with the Flutterglows." Adora falls into step with him, exiting the palace into the gardens. Adora thinks of the bright flying creatures that seem to have taken a liking to her. It's not why she's going into the woods, but she does like them.

"Okay, have fun! I'll be at the target range, I have some new arrow prototypes I want to test." Bow smiles warmly at Adora. He loves the Whispering Woods, the backdrop of carefree childhood memories and the place where he met Glimmer. He's happy to see Adora making more of a connection with it. The wood's unpredictability and organic, unstructured nature was confusing for her when she first got here.

"Good luck with the prototypes! I'll see you later." Adora tells him as they reach the path they'll be following in opposite directions.

And with that, Adora is off to the Whispering Woods for the third time that week. She is getting more practice in baking, and she thinks Madame Razz is starting to expect her.

Adora charges ahead, wanting to make the journey quick. She's almost to the threshold when she feels her boots sink beneath her. She blinks down, seeing the red and white of her shoes surrounded by freshly tilled soil that has been compressed by her hasty steps. Razz usually gathers from what's growing throughout the woods, at least as far as Adora has seen, so she's not sure what to make of this.

A squeaky laugh resonating from inside breaks Adora's reverie. Her muscles flex and she tries to ignore whatever weird thing her throat is doing. She wipes her palms on her pants and strides forward into the cottage.

Catra leans over the counter, kneading dough and laughing. Her back is to the door and she's facing Razz. Adora looks down at the

dough, speckled with cobalt blue flower petals, and notices that Catra's claws are retracted.

Cocky words freeze on Adora's lips as she sees Catra here, looking utterly relaxed in a part of Adora's world. Her brain jump starts when Madame Razz turns to her.

"Hey, Catra. Having a baking day?" Adora smirks, hoping her words will distract Catra from the redness that's overtaken her face.

Catra jolts, turning to her with a hiss. Madame Razz reaches a hand out to place reassuringly on Catra's shoulder. Her ears push back, but to Adora's surprise she does not pull away. Adora can't tell if she's imagining Catra leaning into the touch. *Like she used to do with me* , Adora thinks with a twinge in her gut.

"Oh Mara dearie, don't be rude because Catra is better at baking than you. She has perfected my starflower cake and it is only her second time! She gets them candied just right. You always burn them, bah!" Razz looks over fondly at Catra, waving her broom indistinctly at Adora.

Catra lets out a startled laugh, looking over at Razz with wide eyes before settling into a confident posture with her hand on her hip.

"Aw, are the beginner recipes too hard for you, princess? Did you put gravel in it again?" She sticks out her lower lip, fake pity taking over her expression.

"If I did, would you eat it again?" Adora smiles, crossing her arms and mirroring the sure stance.

"All this talk about cooking for me and all you had to offer this whole time was rocks?"

"Ha! I definitely didn't say I would cook for you. I'd want you to enjoy it."

“Psh, at least you know your weaknesses. I don’t know how you remember them all when there are so many.”

“Alright, Grand Master Chef,” Adora says faux-solemnly, “show me your ways.”

“Since you asked so nicely,” Catra sniffs and turns formally to the sugar solution and blue flowers beside her, setting the dough she was working on aside. She begins to explain the process, delicately painting the flowers and then handing the brush off to Adora.

Adora reaches out eagerly, thrusting her whole body forward and toppling the bowl of sticky hot sugar. It clatters onto the floor, spinning before coming to a halt. Droplets spatter across Catra’s fur. Adora slowly raises her head to meet Catra’s eyes.

“I’m going to fucking kill you,” Catra deadpans.

Before Adora can string her horrified thoughts together to apologize, Catra drops the paintbrush on the counter and turns to Razz.

“Don’t give Adora any of that cake when it comes out of the oven.” And then she’s striding out of the hut again without a second glance.

Adora resists the urge to stomp her feet in frustration like she did when she was a kid. Why was Catra always leaving before they even had a chance to talk properly? It’s not like Adora kept coming here to talk to her, but once they were both here, they might as well. Obviously Catra thought differently.

Why hadn’t she been more careful? She should’ve watched what Catra was doing more closely. She should’ve watched where her stupid arms were going before she broke everything and ruined the afternoon. To add to all that, she still hasn’t told Bow and Glimmer why she is coming here. It looks like she’ll have another lie to tell. Apparently she has no problem lying to her friends, but she can’t lie to herself that this will be her last time coming. She

has to make up for today. She thinks of Catra trying to scrub hardened sugar from her fur in the icy Horde showers and doesn't know how she will.

Madame Razz gives her a piece of cake before she leaves, but it feels worse than gravel scraping dryly down her throat.

***

Adora has a plan. Sort of.

Catra has been detecting First One's artifacts, and Adora has convenient access to one of those. She'd like to meet Catra in her own territory, but Adora can't just go traipsing back into the Fright Zone. She settles for the very edge of the Whispering Woods, barely separated from Horde territory by a stretch of desert. They had driven the skiff here.

Catra rarely needed space from Adora. Usually hissing meant she should get closer. Times have changed, though. She needs a way to show Catra that she's sorry, and that she trusts Catra whether that feeling is reciprocated or not. Adora knows that this is stupid. She shouldn't take such a big risk - one that could affect the rest of the Rebellion - without checking with them, but they wouldn't understand this and she is feeling the kind of impulsive that she only feels around Catra.

Adora snags Bow's least favorite picnic basket - he has many - and goes to the kitchens to stock up. On her way out of the castle, she grabs paper and a thick marker.

Adora gets as close as she dares to the Horde. She leaves her sword on the dense forest floor, setting up the picnic basket stuffed full with crab cakes and elaborate desserts. She ties her brief note to it. It reads "I'm sorry. I thought you'd like these best." She takes a deep breath and walks away. The sword's signal will be strong enough for Catra's tracker to pick up, and after that she'll just have to hope.

***

When Adora comes back the next day to retrieve the sword and see what Catra had made of her apology, she finds everything exactly where she left it. Her stomach drops. Maybe Catra didn’t come after all.

She stoops down to the basket, reaching out to lift it and bracing herself for the stench of spoiled crab. It is almost too heavy to lift. Mystified, she flips open the top of the basket and finds it full of rocks.

A giggle escapes, and then Adora doubles over the basket laughing so hard that tears are streaming down her face. It feels so good to laugh with Catra again, even if she’s not here. She’s starting to have more hope that she might be again.

Chapter End Notes

This fic is all prewritten so I'll be posting chapter updates frequently! The next few chapters are longer, it'll end up being about 18k. Thank you for reading!

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora knows the Fright Zone well. It might have taken a team of Princesses and an apparent casualty to get in last time, but this plan is more simple. She isn't trying to break anyone out this time, she only needs to get herself in.

Adora is hurting more than she should be to try something like this. The pain clouding her thoughts might be the only thing allowing her to go forward with this. Light Hope had pummeled her in training with the hologram of Catra again.

Adora isn't sure if Light Hope knows that the feeling of every injury and wound stays with her after she transforms and they visually disappear. Maybe she knows and thinks She-Ra's training is more important than the deep claw marks she gouges into Adora. And it is more important, Adora knows that. But that combined with the cold crack of taunts thrown at her in Catra's voice drives her here.

Catra may have been threatening her last time Adora saw her, but she hadn't sounded like that. Light Hope's version of Catra sounded like the one Shadow Weaver deployed against her in Mystacor. If anyone is going to be jeering at her, Catra at least deserves to do it herself, for all Adora has put her through.

Adora sneaks out of the castle after dinner and approaches the boundary of the Fright Zone as the sun is sinking. The shifts are changing and there's only one guard stationed this far out. As the new assignee is getting settled in and hasn't pulled their helmet on yet, Adora knocks them out with a strong right hook to the temple. She takes the Horde issue armor and helmet from them, and wonders how the hell she's going to find Catra – she can't go barging into their old bunk room and she doesn't know where

Catra's new room is. She'll have to hope her tried and true solution of finding Catra still works: looking up.

Adora checks a few of Catra's usual hiding places to no avail before she decides to go to their lookout. It feels like wishful thinking, the thought that Catra might still go there. She will be noisy climbing up in her armor, and she's never been graceful in the best of circumstances. She'll just have to hope that this hasn't become someone else's favorite haunt in her absence. Adora begins the craggy ascent, her muscles screaming in protest and her fingers threatening to spasm and drop her with every movement.

Adora pulls herself over the ledge, and there's someone on her immediately. Catra is braced, looking furious and ready to push whoever invaded her space off the roof. Catra falters backward when she realizes it is Adora. Her eyes are wide for a moment like she's seen a ghost, someone long dead she knew would never be with her in this place again, and then something like vindication flickers across her face.

"What, did you come all this way to try to convert me? I'm never going to come play dress up with you," Catra asks derisively, backing away further and trying to rebuild her cool facade after the surprising rush of emotion.

"Razz wanted me to bring you cookies." Adora answers simply, pulling out a rumpled brown paper bag from her pack and holding it out limply. She doesn't step closer to Catra, the bag hanging in the gap between them.

"You're the one that can't stop eating, Adora. It could've waited until the next time I went," Catra scoffs, narrowing her eyes. She doesn't reach out for the cookies. Silence hangs between them as heavy as the desperate offering of amends in Adora's hand.

"If it waited until next time, I wouldn't get to see you. You're never there when I go anymore. And I'm there all the time."

Adora knows she's pouting, but her increasing disappointment doesn't make Razz's ramblings any more palatable.

"Why do you want to see me so bad?" Catra's voice is hard as she crosses her arms and glares at Adora like she's still waiting for that conversion speech. "You left, Adora. What are you doing here?"

"I always want to see you. I hardly want to see anyone but you. I haven't been doing anything except hanging out at Razz's and I usually avoid that place as much as I can. Her advice is confusing and stressful." Adora's shoulders are slumped. She scuffs the toe of her boot along the metal platform, leaving traces in the black dust that has settled there.

Catra has seen Adora timid like this before, when Shadow Weaver's harsh punishments extended to the both of them. She doesn't know what has brought Adora here, like this, with cookies. "You're seeing me right now. What do you want?"

Adora looks at Catra in front of her and thinks of all of the versions of her that Adora has known. When they were at their smallest, they had more freedom than they had yet to find again. They were considered young enough to allow for some of their behaviors, and they had been too young to understand or follow the reprimands for the rest of it. She thinks of the chase and the pleasure in catching each other. Indulging in whims isn't something she has been used to for a long time.

Adora takes a slow step towards Catra. Catra's ears pin back, but she doesn't move. Another step forward. Catra's eyes are wide but she's not trying to leave. Adora closes the gap between them and pulls Catra into a fierce hug.

"Can we have cookies together? Just sit together, like we used to?" Tears cling heavily to Adora's eyelashes as she pulls back to scan Catra's face. She tries to detect any reaction to the open wound that Adora has become in front of her. When Adora could not be a soldier, when she had to lay down the mantle for an hour

or a day, this is where she would come. She has nowhere to go when it becomes too heavy now and her legs are about to give out from the weight.

Catra stays still for a long, excruciating moment. Adora holds herself back, hands trembling with the desire to reach out and breath coiled tight in her lungs. Catra unfreezes slowly, rolling her eyes and slouching down to a seated position on the edge of the lookout.

"Whatever," Catra grouses, as if this doesn't mean anything to her. As if it doesn't mean anything to Adora. "This is not because I like you."

Adora swallows hard as she sits besides Catra, taking a cookie out of the bag and breaking it in half. She holds one half out to Catra and begins to eat her own piece.

Adora places the bag between them and sits in silence, limiting her movement to the slow swing of her feet over the platform. The balance between them is so fragile right now, and Adora has never been good at being delicate. She always trips and she doesn't think she can survive the fall today.

The sun has fully set now. The haze of industrial light fills the sky before them. Catra doesn't move to break the silence, but she flicks her tail several times. The last arc lands it in Adora's lap, a peace offering of her own.

They don't speak again, but Adora stays until the guard watch changes at dawn.

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Adora has the perfect place to hide her newly acquired Horde armor. It would be too risky keeping it at the palace, but she's the only one the woods ever lead to Razz's. If anyone else from the Alliance did end up here, they would never suspect Adora. Razz has plenty of other oddities around her home. In fact, Adora thinks she might have seen her mix pie filling in a Horde helmet

once before. Adora's not sure how she got that, but she wonders if it involved broom-to-face violence.

Hiding her armor is the only reason Adora is going to see Razz today. She's getting a late start. After all, she didn't make it back to her own bed until the early hours of the morning today. She is keenly aware of every lasting sensation from Light Hope's training yesterday, but she feels lighter than she has in weeks. So maybe she's also hoping to see Catra. Fine, whatever, report her to command.

When Adora makes it to the knotted roots of the cottage, Razz isn't tottering around the kitchen whipping something up. She's sitting at her table, gaze loosely focused on the doorway. Adora places the uniform to the side and then approaches.

"Ah, dearie!" Razz exclaims, turning her wide eyed gaze to Adora, "I have been waiting for you. I have been seeing you all day."

"I'm just getting here, Razz. What have you been seeing?" Adora questions, brow furrowed.

"I need to show you. Give me your hand," Razz reaches out her soft pink hand to Adora, her bangles clacking against each other. Adora reaches back, silver rings pressing cooly to her skin as she grasps her hand.

The cottage shimmers around them and Adora is surrounded with images of her and Catra. They're young, no older than eleven in any of the memories. Adora feels her fingers twitching under Razz's firm grasp. She wants to gather the girls behind her and shield them from the world she knows surrounds them.

Adora steps closer to the corner Madame Razz's bed is shoved into. A young Adora and Catra are curled up on it, in a bed much more pink and plush than where this had really taken place. Adora is brushing Catra's hair and giggling at her purr as she gently tugs at it.

Adora is six and Catra has just gotten a new brush. Her mane has grown enough that the standard Horde issued one was no longer manageable. The new brush is made of wood with hard plastic bristles mixed with soft fiber bristles. Adora likes the weight of it in her hand and the tickle of the bristles on her skin.

She watches her little self stare longingly at the brush, slowing her brushing and running her thumb back and forth along the grain of wood. Her bottom lip is starting to jut out in a pout. Catra murmurs a soft questioning sound and the six year old squares her jaw in determination, wide eyes coming back into focus. She begins brushing Catra in earnest again.

Adora remembers this. She was imagining Catra smoothing her own hair back into her signature ponytail with it, how it might feel different from her own boring human brush. She wondered if she would finally be able to purr for real if Catra brushed her hair with it. But Shadow Weaver was furious that Catra had to be issued something custom and made it exceedingly clear that it would not be replaced if this one got damaged. Adora couldn't make Catra risk losing something she needed. So she contented herself with doing this, taking all of her want and imbuing it into the heavy wooden handle of the brush so she wouldn't have to carry it in her heart.

A soldier walks up to the wall in Adora's peripheral vision and she turns to look at the new scene unfolding. Adora is nine and the list of chore assignments has just been tacked up for her squad. Tallying scores is on the list today, as it is every Friday. Adora loves getting time to study her record and understand how each member of her team works. It also gives her access to writing utensils that she can smuggle away for her and Catra to draw with. Her eyes bore holes into the list as her team gathers around to read it.

"What assignment does everyone want?" Lonnie asks the group, casting her eyes around to each person. The silence stretches out for a moment. Lonnie hadn't asked her directly, and it would be selfish of her to try to hog the best assignment. She wasn't asked,

so she doesn't have to answer. Kyle takes his pick and then everyone is chattering and calling dibs. Adora stays quiet until the end, cheerfully accepting the cafeteria duty that was left for last. Adora watches her gap toothed smile falter as she turns to the hallway for her assignment.

Adora's eyes follow her as she fades into the distance, and now Catra and Adora are eleven. They're perched on the stone shelves of the cottage as if they're on a platform in the Fright Zone, legs dangling. Adora is nudging Catra's feet with her own and Catra is pretending not to notice.

"What are we doing for your birthday?" Catra asks.

"It's stupid. We don't have to do anything," Adora deflects, not wanting to ask anything of Catra.

Birthdays have always been something they did for each other in secret, after Adora peaked at their records and found out that they existed. Both of the dates are probably made up, they know at least that Catra wasn't born here, but it's their tradition now. Adora's hesitance is putting Catra on edge. This has always been their time together, and now apparently Adora thinks it's stupid to spend time with her.

"It's not stupid. What do you want to do, Adora?" Her eyes are downcast and her tone is quiet, as fearful as Catra ever allows her voice to be.

"Can we steal extra ration bars and have a sleepover tonight?" Adora bites her lip. Getting the extra food will be risky and Catra will be tired at training tomorrow if they stay up late talking. It's too much to ask, Adora knows it, and she's already regretting the question. But Catra hates it when she doesn't answer questions like that, and the truth slipped out before she could think better of it.

Catra falls into Adora's side, a toothy grin taking over her face and a purr erupting into the warm air of the cottage. "Yeah, Adora,

let's do that."

Adora's face twists as she turns away from the girls to glare at Madame Razz. "Why are you showing me all of this? I already know I miss her."

"Don't settle for missing people, when you could let them love you, Adora. The people you love want you around because you are *you* . They don't want you to disappear, to never ask anything of them. They want to be relied on and appreciated, like they rely on and appreciate you." Razz's large eyes peer out at her imploringly from behind her spectacles.

Adora has been desperate and at the same time utterly repulsed by the idea of talking to anyone about what she's been feeling about Catra. She doesn't understand her own feelings well enough to put it into words. She was there for all of it and she still doesn't get it. Adora feels a tingling behind her nose and a weight between her eyes. Someone else is bringing it up. There is someone she can talk to about her, someone who might understand, even if that understanding was magically acquired. Razz probably won't remember it the next day anyway.

"How do I know what to ask for?" Adora asks. Her voice sounds childish and lost, not far from the tones in the memories surrounding her.

"Like your magic, dearie. Reach inside, and believe what you see. Then, bring it out." Razz describes with awe in her voice, like she's talking about something sacred. "She was brave, my Mara. We must be brave for the people we love, including ourselves."

Adora barely understands how to feel her powers like that. She has a devoted training program just to teach her how to do it, and she still can't turn her sword into anything useful. She's not sure how to grasp something more intangible.

"Catra doesn't want to hear anything I say right now, especially about my feelings." Adora thinks of her chest caving in every time

Catra walks away from Razz's home. Boulders tumble and crash into nothingness, and then the whole structure gives out. She's not sure how to put everything back together. She doesn't think Catra wants her to.

"I could not help my Mara," Razz says, voice watery as her hold on Adora turns into a vice grip. "She got to love, but not for long. It does not have to be like that for you. Don't make me watch it happen again," She says, insistent voice ringing louder. "She-Ra is made for this, *of* this. They cannot keep taking it from her," she ends off sadly.

"Okay, Razz," Adora assures her tremulously, "I won't let it happen again. I promise."

Adora locks eyes with herself at six years old. All of the promises she made to Catra that she did not keep are ringing in her ears. She does not know how she will keep this promise, either.

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"What's got you pouting, kid?" Netossa nudges her foot against Adora's leg as she drops to sit next to her. Dim moonlight pours across the garden, glinting off the silver of Netossa's armor in the darkness. Adora's eye catches on the soft pink necklace around her neck.

"Something Razz was telling me today. You know I can never figure out her advice," Adora replies flippantly. She keeps her gaze focused on the glittering water of the fountain in front of her.

"Want some help decoding it?" Netossa asks with the intensity she always brings to making a battle plan.

"Thanks, Netossa." Adora says flatly, a bit defeatedly. She runs her hands across the white flowers beneath her, tearing leaves off the deadnettle and digging her fingers into the ground.

"That's Adora-speak for you have no plans of telling me, right? So it's not battle plans. Is this a touchy-feely thing? Should I go get

Spinnerella?" Netossa half rises, already moving to go find her wife.

"I don't really want to talk about it with anyone." Adora reaches out, pulling Netossa's wrist to keep her from spreading Adora's pity party further out of containment. She lets go when Netossa settles again.

"Sure. That definitely means you need to talk about it though," Netossa says firmly. She crosses her arms and turns her body to fully face Adora.

"I *can't* tell anyone about it this time," Adora huffs in frustration. No one trusted her when she came here. The angry mob trying to run her out of town and the subsequent interrogation from the queen made that clear. The only reason the Rebellion accepted her is because of She-Ra. If anyone realizes she's the same useless Adora she was when she got here, she won't have a place in the Rebellion anymore. If Catra, by some unexpected miracle, decides to leave the Horde, Adora won't have anywhere safe for her to go. Adora will have defected for nothing, losing everything she has ever cared about.

"Cool, so that proves my point. You definitely need to talk about it. Do you want someone to hold your hand through it or do you want me to tell you the truth about it? You have both options. If you're right that no one else should know about it, me and Spinny won't tell."

Adora puffs out her cheeks, holding her breath and glaring at Netossa. She stays frozen like that, waiting for the other woman to relent. Netossa allows the time to pass in silence.

"I've been seeing Catra," Adora rushes out, face flushing red and eyes focused upward to the sky.

"Catra Catra? As in your archnemesis from the Horde?" Netossa asks, brow furrowed. She does not have enough context for that to clarify anything.

“No! She was my friend, my best friend. Before I defected, anyway. She’s never been my nemesis, whatever I am to her now.” Adora thinks of the punch in the gut at the Sea Gate, of Catra falling off a cliff rather than holding onto her hand at Princess Prom. But she has more important memories with Catra. Her rumble at the end of the bed at night, the hidden spaces in the Fright Zone. Even recently at the beach and Razz’s; all of those memories outweigh the bad.

“Your friend?” Netossa raises an eyebrow. Adora’s gaze was distant and her voice was soft. Netossa used to talk about her best friend in a similar tone.

“Yes. My- well. We never had other words for it. That’s what we called it.” Adora replies softly.

A knowing look sparkles in Netossa’s eyes. She looks fondly at Adora, thinking back to a similar conversation she’d had with her older sister. She had realized her feelings for Spinny just a few weeks before then. “Okay. You’ve been seeing her. What does that mean?”

“We’ve just been -- going to the same places. I saw her when I was in Salineas before Glimmer’s birthday. And then I’ve been seeing her in the woods. She hardly lets me talk, though. She keeps leaving when I show up.”

“What's the alternative to her leaving?” It sounds like Adora wants Catra to stay, maybe even to come to Brightmoon. That seems unlikely with what she saw unfold at Princess Prom, but there was obviously more between them than she knew. Now that she thinks about it, they had danced together, even if they ended up dangling off a cliff afterwards.

“I don’t know! Coming here, coming to any of the kingdoms, anywhere but the Horde. They aren’t-- she doesn’t deserve the way they treat her.” Adora doesn’t have any of this planned out. She hates going into anything without a plan, but she can’t predict Catra like she used to be able to.

“You’d be fine with her going somewhere else? And you’d stay here?” Netossa asks, trying to keep her tone neutral. It’s obviously a leading question, but Adora’s so oblivious that laying it on thick usually helps.

“As long as she’s doing what she wants to and she’s happy, yeah I’d be fine with it.” Adora swallows hard. Catra didn’t want to follow Adora where she had gone. She made that much clear in Thaymor.

“And what do you want, Adora?” Netossa pokes, trying to replicate the gentle tones she’s so familiar with from her wife.

Adora bites down hard on her bottom lip, leaving white crescent marks there in her wake. She digs her fingers deeper into the ground beneath her. She’s not sure she can understand what people are talking about when they talk about wanting. She feels pulled to action sometimes, but she can never put the patterns together. She’s not sure what to label as desire, so even when she thinks she has an answer, she’s too afraid to say it. She knows she can’t have it anyway. “I’ve been getting a lot of questions I don’t have answers to today.”

“Think about it. It sounds like part of you knows.” Netossa reaches over and squeezes Adora’s shoulder. “Your secret is safe with us. You’re going to be okay, Adora. It feels the most confusing and overwhelming at the start. You’ll look up one day and be surprised at how much more clear it’s all gotten. Give it some time.”

Adora tries to follow Madame Razz’s instructions. She tips back into the grass, laying down and letting her arms fall loosely around her. Her ponytail presses harshly into the ground beneath her, and she yanks her hair tie out. She relaxes again and concentrates. She thinks of herself as a well, of everything she’s feeling as something physical she can draw up with the simple pull of a rope.

Adora can think of two things she might want, but she doesn’t know how she can get one without destroying the other.

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Adora stills as she approaches Razz's cottage. Catra is kneeling in the freshly dug garden beds lining the front of the house. Adora studies her as she gets closer. She's not very familiar with plants but she's seen Perfuma working out in the gardens. Adora approaches the bed on the other side of the door, mirroring Catra's position on the ground. Adora peaks out of the corner of her eye, burying her hands in the dirt and trying to match the size of the hole Catra is digging.

Catra pauses for a moment when she sees Adora approach. Catra swallows, focusing on the dark loam sticking under her claws. She reaches her hand out, grasping a warm orange bulb from her pile and rolling it towards Adora. "It's Winter Aconite. Plant it two inches down, three inches from the next one you plant. Don't crowd them."

Adora reaches out to pick up the bulb gently, her touch almost a caress. She flicks her gaze up to Catra, shy and hopeful. Catra glances away, just slow enough to reveal the fact that she had been looking. Adora doesn't press her luck. She tucks the bulb into the space she created, gently brushing soil over it and then scooting to the next spot. She's listening intently for every movement Catra makes, trying to keep track of her without staring too much. She watches Catra handle the plants with care, precise with her spacing and delicate as she covers them with soil, and gives up not looking.

Catra lets out a chirrup she hastily tries to stifle, face hot and looking steadfastly in front of her. Adora looks over at her to see her cupping a handful of soil, baby-pink worms slowly shifting through. Catra smoothly rests them in a spot where she's already planted a flower so they'll be out of danger from digging. Adora is smiling fondly at her, eyebrows raised a bit in the center in surprise.

Catra doesn't even look at her before scoffing and saying, "Shut up. They're good for the plants, that's the only reason I'm doing

this," Catra is usually a more convincing liar than Adora, but there are exceptions to everything.

Adora's smile stays in place, but she doesn't push the topic any further. She understands, anyway.

"Perfuma's been trying to get me out in the garden for awhile," She changes the subject, trying to push her hair poof back into place as she raises her head, smudging dirt across her forehead in the process. She blinks as she hears a quiet growl from Catra. "I never agreed to it. But I want to learn now." She doesn't say *now that I'm learning with you* . She didn't used to be afraid of harsh words from Catra, not when every swipe was followed by a hug. Not when fighting was playing. She is afraid now, but she can't stop wanting. Maybe this is what wanting looks like.

Another bulb rolls towards her, nudging against her knee buried in the dirt. She accepts it in place of words that can't be said yet. After her next bulb is planted, she starts moving down the line in Catra's direction. When they're planting side by side, Adora brushes her hand against Catra's as they're both reaching for another bulb. She nudges their shoulders together as they're planting, inches their knees together. They're small, incidental touches that would look accidental if anyone were watching. It's how they danced around each other when someone *was* watching. Just like it was then, it goes unacknowledged from both sides.

Adora clears her throat as the stack of bulbs dwindles down to only one. "Are you staying to bake today?"

"Maybe next time, Adora."

"Okay. I'll be here."

Chapter End Notes

Winter Aconite is the first flower to bloom after a long frost :) Check out the playlist for this fic here. Would love to hear any and all thoughts in the comments! Thank you for reading!

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Netossa's words have been ringing in Adora's head like she's back in Alwyn, the echoes of haunted Princesses following her. Adora doesn't know how to make a plan to get what she wants. First, because there are more important things than what she wants and second, because the things she wants are irreconcilable; she can't fight with the Rebellion and be with Catra like she used to be. So Adora doesn't know how to make a plan, but she has an instinct in this moment and she's willing to follow it.

Bow and Glimmer are huddled in the dining room, planning a sleepover for the best friend squad. Adora is sitting across the table from them, her eyes fixed on the pair but glazed over as she picks at the skin around her fingers. She doesn't notice the small traces of blood and neither do her friends, her hands tucked away under the table in her lap.

"Oooh, Adora! We can do another pillow fight! No holds barred, we can all use our powers," She gestures to Bow, smiling brightly at him, "and arrows! There were so many feathers all over my room last time, it took me like two months to get them all out. My mom was so mad," Glimmer dissolves into a fit of giggles, thinking about her mom's stern look when she came face to face with the silliness Glimmer had initiated at their sleepover.

They had a skirmish at a nearby village today with some upgraded bots the Horde sent their way. Glimmer is still high on the adrenaline she gets from battle, ecstatic at finally being able to be involved in the fight. She has been begging her mom for this since long before She-Ra was a thought in her head.

Adora is not feeling a similar euphoria. She smiles thinly at Glimmer as she continues reminiscing. She-Ra takes the hits that

Bow and Glimmer would not survive, or at least would not easily stand back up from. And here Adora is, all in one piece. She is grateful for it. And she feels every screaming muscle, every gaping wound. Her joints feel like they are in the wrong place with every movement, like bone is scraping into bone. She wants to double over. She pulls herself up more, back stiffening to hold herself up straighter.

Adora was used to getting battered and bruised in training alongside her squad. You hid the pain, but there was no need to hide the bruises. Your team watched it happen, and they carried marks of their own. It was an expected outcome.

Glimmer and Bow expect She-Ra to be invincible, untouchable. They expect her to be whole. She-Ra can't do that for her. She is still Adora underneath it all. All she can do is keep Adora standing for long enough to take more hits than she ever could've withstood on her own. It is an essential asset to the Rebellion, and Adora would take up the sword again in an instant if she was given the choice.

Adora is used to hiding her pain from the world at large, but she's never had to do it without Catra before, the one person she didn't have to hide from. She misses the exception to the rule.

When you got sick in the Horde, you stayed out of sight, but she could always trust Catra to find a dark corner to help her hide away. She would bring Adora rations, always the gray kind when she was sick. She would push the sweat soaked strands clinging to Adora's forehead away and press a washcloth snuck out from the showers damply across her forehead or her neck.

Catra knew she wasn't invincible and she loved her anyway. Adora had been papering over all the tender spots she had always left for Catra, crafting a thin veneer of acceptance with the knowledge that she would never get what they had back. But here Catra was, finding all of the chinks in her armor again, reminding Adora of when it was safe to let someone in.

Adora doesn't think she can accept her life without that kind of love anymore, not without trying to get it back. Not when everyone older and wiser is telling her that she *can* get it back, no matter how impossible it seems. Whether she can or not, Catra has at least been accepting her presence lately. Adora isn't strong enough not to push that when given the opening.

"That sounds great, Glim, but I want to be up early for training tomorrow morning. I'm going to go ahead and head to bed in my room. We can plan the pillow fight for another time soon."

Glimmer pouts good-naturedly and Bow and Glimmer both send her off to bed warmly. Adora forces herself to keep her steps slow as she makes her way out of the dining wing. She doesn't go back to her room. She keeps walking, making her way to the Whispering Woods.

Adora stops at Razz's, pulling on her ill-gotten Horde attire. Razz sends her off with muffins to share. As she's leaving, she hesitates as she looks at the small yellow buds growing from the bulbs they had planted in front of the cottage. She thinks about bringing some to Catra, biting her lip as she thinks of a similar gesture she had seen between Castaspella and Juliet. She keeps walking.

The soft pattering of her boots against dense foliage turns into dull thuds on cracked and dry stone as she makes her way across the desiccated landscape. Shadows of training drills, dozens of cadets marching in tandem, follow her path. A skiff whizzes by in her memory, when this barren land looked like the promise of a new future full of opportunities as Force Captain. She aches for how simple it felt then.

When she makes it to the perimeter of the Fright Zone, Adora knocks out a guard again and makes her way back to their lookout, just barely keeping their muffins intact on the ascent. She is alone here today in the dim evening, just a few minutes before lights out will be called. With dawning dread, Adora realizes she is going to have to try to track Catra to her new Force Captain quarters. She thinks of the drag down fight when they had

rescued Glimmer, and knows she is in no shape to win that battle now. She'll just have to avoid suspicion, because she's not turning back now.

She moves to the building where she knows their lodgings are from her brief tour at Force Captain orientation. She walks in with a confidence she does not feel and no one pays her any mind. Adora spots a flash of red down the hall. Sticking to the wall, she makes her way in that direction as fast as she dares. She sees which door Catra wanders into and ducks into a supply closet, not daring to follow before lights out with so many people crowding the hallway.

Adora sits in wait, trying to moderate her breathing. She doesn't know what Catra will do when she enters, but she's fairly certain she won't alert the guards. Catra had helped her escape when they rescued Glimmer, and their relationship had been in a far worse place then. But the more she expects, the more she hopes, the easier it gets to hurt her. Catra can hurt her a hundred different ways without having to raise a single alarm, while Adora is here with all of her guards lowered, willing and wanting and dreading the blow of rejection.

Eventually, Adora hears the lights click off. She waits a few minutes longer, and then she emerges into the dim green glow of the hallway. Adora shuffles over to the door she saw Catra enter, quickly tapping out the secret knock they used as children to give Catra a brief warning of her presence. She slides the door open and slips inside.

Catra is on her feet, eyes lasered in on the door. She looks relieved when she sees it is Adora, tensed stance relaxing slightly. Adora's not sure if she's relieved that it isn't someone else using that knock against her, or if she's actually happy to see Adora.

"Hi, Catra," Adora says in a tone softer and more reserved than she usually does.

Catra rolls her eyes. “Hey, Adora. You look stupid in that armor, it doesn’t fit you right,”

“Sorry, Force Captain. I’ll make sure my equipment is in order at our next training session,” she jokes weakly.

Catra’s mask is off, laying on the metal table bolted down next to her bed. Her curls fall loosely around her face.

“How’re private quarters treating you? I couldn’t sleep through the night alone for months.”

“I’ve earned them. I’d rather be away from watchful eyes.”

Adora doesn’t think she ever fell into that category. She draws closer.

Adora looks down at Catra’s bunk and sees the blanket they shared through their whole childhood. The edges are shredded. It wasn’t like that last time Adora saw it.

Adora is uncertain on her feet and every part of her hurts. She edges to the bed and hovers her hand over the blanket, looking at Catra for approval. She gets an impassive stare back. Good enough. Catra makes her disapproval clear. She pulls the blanket over her lap and lifts the other half, turning to Catra again shyly. Catra hesitantly sits on the bed beside her.

Adora places the bag from Razz’s on the table without explanation, tipping her head over to rest on Catra’s shoulder. Catra raises her arm to curl around Adora’s waist, resting her hand where hours before a stun gun had dug deep into her side. Adora lets in a silent but sharp exhale through her nose, just barely flinching away. Silent to most ears, at least, but not to Catra’s. Catra knows what Adora sounds like when she’s hurt, the telltale way Horde kids stifle their reactions.

Catra narrows her eyes, immediately moving to raise the bottom of Adora’s white compression shirt to check for injuries. Her skin is unmarred, not even a fading bruise in sight. Catra sits back,

leveling Adora with a look. “Are you hurt?” she accuses, trying to make sense of Adora’s reaction and her unblemished skin.

Adora falls back onto the bed beneath her, glaring at the ceiling and avoiding Catra’s eye. “I don’t look hurt, do I?” she asks sullenly.

“No, you don’t. But I doubt the Princesses have gotten you to go so soft in just a couple months that you’re gasping in pain from - what, nothing at all?” Adora hadn’t gasped in pain, but she may as well have from how well Catra can read her reactions. Adora bites down on her lip hard and balls her fists tight at her sides until her knuckles turn white.

She wants the comfort of Catra’s presence, but she wants to pretend that there isn’t a reason she needs it. Adora can slip into this persona like it’s her second skin; she spends more time in it than out of it. But her careful control requires everyone else to play along, and Catra’s analytical gaze strips her bare. Now that they're face to face, going on without her feels unfathomable. But she can't admit why. It would be weak and weakness isn't an option. Not for She-Ra, and not for Adora either.

“That’s why you’re here, isn’t it? So tell me. Are you hurt?” Catra demands. Her words are angry but her eyes crease with worry and betray her concern.

“Fine! Yes. Are you happy now?” The words burst from Adora like steam erupting, pressure building so high that staying closed off becomes impossible. Angry tears threaten to spill from her eyes. Gravity holds them in place as she keeps her eyes up to the ceiling.

Catra lets out a harsh breath. She walks out, entering the small adjacent bathroom without looking back at Adora. Great, Adora has pushed her too far, revealed too much. This is not what they are to each other anymore, and Catra is unwilling to accept this burden that she never asked for. Catra can’t storm into the hallway without raising suspicion, so she’ll hide out in the

bathroom until Adora leaves. Adora tries to muster her remaining energy to pull herself from the room, not wanting to leave Catra sequestered in the bathroom for long.

To her surprise, Catra reenters the bedroom moments later.

She approaches the bed, knocking Adora's fist away from her side and laying something cool and damp on the place where Catra had touched. Adora blinks down and sees a washcloth folded across her skin. She closes her eyes and stays still, willing the tears at bay. Catra cups Adora's fist and presses into her fingers lightly until Adora unfurls her hand, allowing her muscles to relax. Catra lies on her back on Adora's good side. She shifts closer until their arms are pressed together from shoulder to fingertip. Catra links their pinkies together and squeezes.

"What's wrong? Why don't you look hurt?" Catra speaks into the quiet hum of the room.

Adora clears her throat, trying to steady her voice before she speaks. "It looks like it heals when I'm not She-Ra anymore." Adora tenses, nervous at the admission and nervous to say her name around Catra.

"But it doesn't feel like it heals?" Catra asks levelly.

"No. I feel it all." Adora confesses on an exhale.

Anger bubbles up Catra's throat. "And they still send you out to take hits like that?" she spits out, indignant on Adora's behalf. It's misdirected, but it's a familiar feeling to be defended by Catra like this and it makes her feel warm down to her toes.

"I didn't tell them, Catra. They need me." The thought threatens to bring the permafrost back into her veins. Adora presses herself closer to Catra, trying to focus on the warmth of her touch instead.

Catra scoffs, "You're a good fighter, Adora. Probably better with all that extra height. You don't have to take infinite hits, too. If your

stupid friends are worth anything, they should know that."

Adora wants to be able to believe her reassurance, but Catra didn't see what it was like when Adora joined the Rebellion. "They accepted me because I'm She-Ra. The people of Bright Moon tried to run me out of town when I first showed up, before I transformed. Disclosing physical weakness… My standing with them isn't solid enough to take that,"

"Would they accept me if I showed up?"

"What? If- if you wanted to. Yes! I'll vouch for you. You can go anywhere you want, any kingdom. I know you - don't want to be around me. You don't have to be. I can talk to them."

"I can't take infinite hits, though. I'm just a good fighter. Doesn't sound like that meets their standards. Sounds like we'd both be on shaky ground if I left here," Catra tells her.

"Bow doesn't have any powers at all. He's good at what he does, but he would've been accepted there even if he didn't want to fight," Adora insists.

"So that's true for everyone else, but not true for you then. You're so special you still get your own rules, huh, Adora?" Catra challenges.

"I- I don't know. Maybe they would be okay with it. Maybe it wouldn't change the tide of the war. But the only way for me to find out is to tell them, and by then it'll be too late. There are more important things at stake here than how I'm feeling."

Catra's not sure why she's fighting for Adora to solidify her place in the Rebellion. That's not really what she wants. But knowing how She-Ra's powers work, coming back here can't be an option. Shadow Weaver would never accept fallibility from Adora. Whatever the Rebellion is making her endure, Shadow Weaver and Hordak would be worse.

Catra thinks about the claws she's torn into She-Ra. That's something she never would've done to Adora, not past careless swipes as a kitten and rough housing as teenagers. But she'd been doing it to Adora unknowingly anyway. Adora carried all of those marks. Catra wishes she had had a choice in that. She thinks the Rebellion brats might want the same. She's not willing to make that point, to send Adora back into their arms and away from here. Adora came to her. Catra can still take care of her like they used to do for each other.

"So it's your side. Tell me where else," Catra prompts, shifting in the bed to look at Adora.

Catra wraps their old blanket around Adora, encouraging her to shift further into the bed. She moves the washcloth to each area Adora hesitantly indicates, refreshing the cool water occasionally.

"Do you want a gray ration bar or tiny food? Entrapta has single handedly changed food manufacturing here, only for herself," Catra tells her, a hint of a fond smile raising her lips.

"Ration bar, please," Adora whispers, smiling softly at Catra from her spot on the bed. Her eyes have been watery for this whole interaction and the gesture isn't helping.

Catra slips out of the room to get them, returning a few minutes later. Catra sits on the floor, leaning against the cool metal of the bed frame. She unwraps both bars, passing one to Adora. They eat together quietly, and then Catra flicks off the light. She curls up at the end of the bed like they used to, careful to stay clear of the invisible injury on Adora's knee. Adora falls into a deep slumber, and slips out of the Fright Zone just before lights on the next morning.

Catra finds the paper bag Adora brought from Razz's on her night stand that morning. She eats honeyberry muffins for breakfast that day. When she pulls out the last one, something catches her eye at the bottom of the bag. When she peers in, she sees a single yellow bloom outlined against the brown paper.

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Catra is perched on the bough of a tree, picking small oblong red fruits growing in clusters. Razz told her they were called miracle berries, which sounds like some magic bullshit to her. She hasn't thought of a better name yet, though. She drops a handful of berries into the basket wedged beside her, catching a flash of movement as she turns. She whips around, looking for a glint of blonde hair, but Adora isn't there.

Catra sees a woman she's never met approaching the tree. She has dark skin and a short shock of blue curls pushed to one side. She's wearing silver and blue armor with a discordant pink necklace on. Her arms are crossed and her muscles are tense. She looks ready to jump into action at the first provocation. She's definitely not Horde, so there's only one camp she could be coming from. The woman stops in full view of her, placing her hands on her hips and raising her eyebrow. "Catra, right?"

Did Adora send someone after her? Catra let her waltz into the Fright Zone free and clear, and now apparently Adora is determined to ruin the one good thing she had found. Catra claws extend smooth and fast, hidden behind the foliage. She doesn't descend from her vantage point. "What's it to you?"

"I'm not here to fight. You'd already be out of that tree if I was. I'm a friend of Adora's. I just want to talk."

"Yeah, that's not a great endorsement. Adora's friends try to kill me every time they see me." Catra replies derisively.

"Right, and I'm sure you always keep those claws away. I'm not here as a member of the Alliance, I'm here as an adult that has her life 70% more figured out than you stupid kids. I'm here as somebody that cares about Adora. It was pretty clear talking to her yesterday that hurting you wouldn't do her any good,"

Catra bristles at that. Catra didn't want to be fodder for gossip around their sparkly pink table. "You and all your rebel pals have

been hanging around talking about me?”

Netossa rolls her eyes. “Only me and my wife know. Adora was spiraling and I bullied it out of her. She didn’t set out to tell me. Neither of us are going to say anything. You kids will figure it out, but you’ve got enough outside shit making it harder. You don’t need us adding anything. And I figured you could use a little help,” Netossa begrudgingly reassures.

“I don’t need you stalking me in the woods and I definitely don’t need a Princess's help with anything,” Catra scoffs. The branches she’s gripping onto emanate threatening creaks as her grasp tightens.

“You don’t need it. I’m sure you two would figure it out eventually. But you might want it.”

“What do you think you know about me and Adora?” Catra spits out, narrowing her eyes and leaning down closer to where Netossa stands in the clearing.

“I know the way Adora looks when she’s talking about you. I know *how* she talks about you. I know she chases you down in every single fight. You always come out unscathed even though she’s eight feet tall and brimming with magic. I know that I’m your enemy, but for some reason you haven't tried to kick my ass yet. You wouldn’t be able to, by the way, so don’t try it. My wife will be mad at me if I beat you up but I will absolutely do it anyway.”

Catra chuffs, darting her eyes to the side to break eye contact. “What's a wife?” she asks, jutting out her chin and crossing her arms.

Netossa starts, her always battle ready stance relaxing a fraction. “Well. She’s the most important person to me. She’s someone that I look out for before everyone else. And she’s someone I’ve promised to be with for a long time. I love her,” Netossa’s hand traces the mismatched pink necklace before dropping back down

to her side. She doesn't explain the object, but Catra guesses it might be her wife's.

"Oh." Catra shifts, turning her back to Netossa and making her way down from her perch. Her face is hidden in the shadows as she turns away, scaling back down to the ground. Catra wonders if she could ever trust Adora to keep a promise like that, a promise of a long time together, when she's broken all the most important ones. But Catra can't stop thinking about the beach, about Adora deciding to stay, about her coming back to the Fright Zone to see her. Catra stomps down on the traitorous spark of hope that flares to life in her chest, as she always does.

"So. Do you want my help or not?"

"I can't stop you from saying whatever stupid princessy thing you want to tell me." Catra still isn't fully looking at Netossa but she turns enough that Netossa can see half her face. Catra stares attentively at her claws dragging lines into the dirt.

"Okay, see, now you're really tempting me to not be helpful. But I'm an actual adult so I will overlook that. Like you said, I don't know everything about you and Adora, but she always comes out of your fights unharmed, too. Why is this fight important to you, Catra? And is it the most important thing to you? Because it doesn't have to be." Netossa lets her words hang in the air, watching calculations occurring behind Catra's eyes once she registers the question.

"I told Adora to think about what she wants, to let herself want it," Netossa continues.

Catra snorts at that, muttering "Yeah, that's never been her strong suit."

Netossa ignores the side comment with only an eye roll, continuing "Maybe you need to think about what you want, too. Would winning Hordak's stupid war for him really make you happy? Would it be worth it, when it hurts you and Adora in the

end? I fight because I want to protect the people that I love. I don’t know what I would be fighting for, if I didn’t have the chance of being with them after it's all over.”

“Oh, how noble of you. Whatever. You Princesses are all the same. You think you know so much better than everyone else. Why would I take advice from someone willingly wandering into enemy territory to talk about feelings? This is exactly what I want.” Catra dismisses, tone mocking. As the words slip out, she realizes that Netossa is not the one in enemy territory.

Catra doesn’t give her time to reply, to throw her own hypocrisy and weakness back at her, darting through the trees back the way she came. When Netossa turns away from the fading movement in the trees, she sees a basket of berries at her feet. She drops them off at Razz’s before she heads home. Her and Adora would be good for each other.

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“Adora, wait!” Glimmer catches the sleeve of Adora’s jacket before she has a chance to leave the war room, her shimmering cape fluttering behind her with the hasty movement. The rest of the Princesses are filtering out into the hallways already.

“I feel like I’ve hardly seen you lately. Are you doing okay?” Glimmer checks in, sliding her hand down from Adora’s wrist to her hand and squeezing lightly.

“Why wouldn’t I be okay?” Adora deflects, fingers loosely tangled with Glimmer’s. A metal door slams down into place in her abdomen like a code has just been entered to seal a passage off in the Fright Zone. Her confessions could not escape her now even if she tried. They are pushed down somewhere too far and too well guarded for her to reach.

“I’m not sure. You just haven’t been at the palace much lately. Bow and I miss you. It’s okay if you need some space, I know adjusting to being here has been hard. I just want you to know

that you can talk to us. It's okay if it's not right now," Glimmer reassures her, keeping Bow's reminder of not pushing Adora too hard in mind.

"Thanks, Glimmer. I'm okay, really. I just wanted to go on a walk. You know how I get sitting still too long in these meetings." Adora tells her, squeezing her hand once before dropping the hold and taking a step back, boots clinking on the smooth marble of the palace floor. She needs to get out from Glimmer's analyzing focus.

"Okay, no problem. We'll be here, Adora." Glimmer raises her hand in farewell as Adora walks out into the hall. Glimmer stays where she is, watching as Adora reappears through the window and makes her way into the Whispering Woods. She stamps down on the frustration rising in her chest. Bow is right. Adora will talk to them when she's ready. She disappears into a flash of sparkles, teleporting into the group of chatting Princesses out in the hallway.

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Catra is sitting on the stoop outside of Razz's house, glaring into the distance. She rises as soon as she sees Adora approaching, storming up to her and poking a finger into her sternum. "Heard you've been gossiping about me with your little friends."

Adora freezes in shock, reeling back at the touch. "What- Catra-" Adora stammers out. She raises her hand and curls her fingers around Catra's outstretched hand.

"I can explain! I'm sorry."

Catra sulks back to the stoop, dropping back into her previous position. Adora walks over hesitantly. She sits next to Catra, leaving a safe gap between them that she wishes wasn't necessary.

"Did you hear me with Netossa? I'm sorry. She's the only one that knows other than Razz. I shouldn't have said anything. I shouldn't

have betrayed your trust like that. I just don't know where we stand and I don't know how to keep moving like everything is normal. She caught me on a bad day. She said she wouldn't tell anyone other than her wife Spinerella." Adora rambles, hands fumbling in front of her.

"Really? You expect me to believe she's the only one that knows? You didn't tell Sparkles and Boy?" Catra accuses, but some of the heat has dropped from her gaze at the apology. Adora was always good at making her let go of anger that she should have carried to the end of the universe.

"They know I come out to the Whispering Woods to see Razz. I wouldn't be able to explain how often I'm gone if I didn't tell them that. They don't know that I see you here. Bow knows that I saw you in Salineas. He thinks I was trying to stop you from digging up that tech." Adora justifies. Catra knows all of her tells and she doesn't want to lie to her anyway. Adora had put them both in jeopardy by telling Netossa. Catra deserved to know that, but she should also know that's as far as it went.

"Why didn't you try to stop me, Adora? Why'd you even stop your boat?" Catra pries, needing Adora to say more than what she has offered. She has been on her back foot, off balance and unsteady since the net princess tracked her down in the woods.

"Because I wanted to. I've always had to prioritize our mission before anything else. The sword didn't change that, it just shifted what the mission was. But that day on the beach, I don't know. I just wanted to see you — I kind of can't stop thinking about it," Adora admits.

"All of our commanders were so full of shit. I don't understand why you thought the mission was so important." Catra doesn't say the second part. *Why wasn't I important too?*

"It felt like the only thing I was allowed to care about. Everything else felt selfish, and maybe cruel. Taking for myself at the expense of everyone else, when we were supposed to be protecting all of

Etheria. That's what everyone told me was important. You called me gullible, right? And you know me better than anyone," Adora replies, a bitter lilt to her voice. She believes in what she's doing now, in the Rebellion. But she's not sure if she trusts herself to know what's worth fighting for anymore. She's not sure it's worth giving up everything for, not if everything includes this – not if she doesn't have to.

Catra thinks of who they were raised by. All of Adora's decisions were haunted by an example of someone who always took, always demanded more, who gave soft touches and kind words only when it was convenient to her end goals. There was something to be said for being the opposite of what Shadow Weaver was. They had so few examples of balance that Catra isn't sure she can conceptualize what it looks like, but it sounds better than either of the options she's seeing now.

"Right, and then you let the Rebellion dupe you a second time. They didn't even have to brainwash you for years. How convenient for them." Was it any different, the Rebellion taking Adora because she was *useful* , just because they sparkled when they did it? Making it pretty doesn't make it hurt any less.

"Catra, how has it been for you there? Since I left?" Adora's hand hovers over Catra's, tentatively reaching out and huffing out a breath when Catra allows the touch. Adora feels the cool slip of her extended claws as she intertwines their fingers.

Catra hisses at the question, shifting further away on the step but allowing their hands to stay connected. Catra watches the yellow Aconite around them swaying gently. There's no breeze today, so it must be the rippling magic of the forest. She tries to stay grounded here, to not be whisked away to the electric vice Shadow Weaver had snared her in as soon as Adora ran out on her.

"It's been shit, Adora, how do you think it's been? You grew up with her too. And then you defected and left me to deal with the consequences."

"I'm so sorry, Catra," Adora squeezes her hand. She doesn't rush forward to justify herself or argue. She lets the admission sit in the air between them for a moment.

"It was shit when we were growing up too. I wanted us out of there. I wanted *you* out of there. You're smarter than me, and you had it harder so you had to learn faster. There was never an option for you to succeed, but I thought if I performed well enough I could change things for both of us. That was stupid to believe. I didn't know that you already understood all of it; that you thought I understood and wanted us to stay there. I thought once you knew, it would change things like it did for me."

Adora's gaze is pleading. She wants to shuffle closer, to feel like the sinkhole that had opened up between them and left a cavern where their friendship had once been would not stretch on forever. But she holds herself back, respecting the distance Catra has placed between them.

She can't hold back everything, though. "I guess I'm wondering if it's okay for me to want something if I only want one thing."

"What do you want, Adora?" Catra asks, voice softer than Adora has heard it in a long time. It makes her heart squeeze painfully.

Adora takes a deep breath, trying to convince herself that she'll be able to keep her voice steady. She replays Razz's words, thinking of the well of desire that she has been working so hard to draw from. Her hands are trembling, but she makes no effort to still them. Catra has seen her already, and there is no use pretending that Catra does not know all these parts of her, even the ones she'd prefer to keep tucked away.

With a last steadying breath, Adora seeks out Catra's eyes again. "I want to see you. To see you all the time, not only when we're sneaking around. I don't want to have to act like it's a coincidence and that I don't care when you leave. I want to tell Bow and Glimmer about you because you'll come back with me. I'm not

asking you to. I know you don’t want to. But that’s the truth.” Adora confesses on an exhale.

Catra doesn’t say anything for a long time. They sit in the quiet woods, listening to the soft chatter of animals in the distance. Eventually, Catra rises to her feet and pulls Adora up by their connected hands. She tugs Adora into the cottage and asks Razz what they’re going to bake that day.

Chapter End Notes

We're really in it now, folks! Thank u for reading!

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

> We will be hurt but I promise we will also be comforted! This chapter is on the shorter side but we have a long one coming next.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra gasps in desperate breaths, clinging to the metal wall supporting her weight. She trembles, her mind still trapped in the airless chamber Hordak had created even after her body escaped. A shaking hand reaches for her chest, pressing hard as she tries to focus on the rise and fall of her lungs.

She drags herself back to her quarters. Panicked tears drip from her unwilling eyes and she hastily smears them away. She used to have somewhere to go when she had been pushed over the edge. Adora would come to her before she even had to ask. Now, the crashing and droning of Fright Zone operations echo dully around her empty room.

Catra is going to Razz's. Adora won't be there, she's never seen her this late at night. But seeing Razz will be enough. Not being in this hollow, echoing room will be enough. She stalks out of the Fright Zone, sticking to the shadows but not going through any extraordinary lengths to avoid detection. She's second-in-command – any rookie guard that spots her won't have the nerve to question her, let alone face Hordak to report her.

She travels in a haze, the cool stone under her feet only registering in the background. When she makes it into the woods, she approaches the cottage. She averts her eyes. She keeps walking. Her legs carry her deeper into the woods than she has ever been.

When she reaches the boundary of the woods, she stares at the cold and imposing figure of Brightmoon Palace. A small strip of

land ascends to the mountainous crags the fortress rests on. Catra swallows, looking at the dark depths of water surrounding it. Being less than two feet away from water for the whole trip to the hostile castle wouldn't be comforting on her best day. Nonetheless, she pushes forward.

Catra sneaks around the palace, moving to the back and trying to locate the living quarters. She assures herself that the Princesses must have allocated their precious She-Ra her own bedroom.

Light glows softly from one of the windows, in what could be an attempt to replicate the glowing green that never fully dimmed in their bunk room. Catra perks her ears up, trying to tune everything else out and focus on that one room. She hears thudding footsteps -- pacing.

Catra draws out the grappling hook she hardly had enough awareness to snag on her way out. She could climb this height easily without it, but speed and silence will work in her favor here. The hook whizzes through the air, latching on to the ledge of the window. She hoists herself up, ears twitching. The edge of the window rises just barely to her eye line, and she freezes, peering in. A sigh escapes her. Adora's form is moving back and forth in the room, mercifully alone. She chose correctly.

Claws slide underneath the embellished gold frame, nudging it open. The frame slides open until she has enough room to slip inside. She grasps the ledge with both hands to lift herself up, raising her eyes from where she's been maneuvering the window. Adora is frozen in the middle of the room, eyes wide and mouth hanging open. "Catra?" Adora stares in disbelief, wondering if it is possible to wish for something so hard that it materializes in front of her.

"Don't make a big deal out of it," Catra replies sullenly. Adora rushes forward to help pull Catra through the window, but she has already landed on the plush carpet by the time Adora gets close. Catra slides the window closed behind her and lets the grappling hook pool between their feet.

Now that Catra has the safety of solid ground beneath her, the adrenaline that carried her here fades. She is trembling again. "Catra?" Adora questions again, softly this time. Her brow creases with worry. She seems to hesitate for a moment, but she reaches out to hold Catra's waist without asking. Adora's not sure that Catra could stay on her feet without the support.

"Come here," Adora murmurs, using her grip to lightly lead Catra to sit on the edge of the bed. Catra wouldn't be here if it hadn't been bad. Adora lets her eyes fall shut for a moment, crackling red bolts flashing behind her lids as she remembers other days that had put Catra in this state. She doesn't take that lightly.

Adora pulls Catra close into her arms. She tilts them back until they are both laying on their sides on the bed. They are laying horizontally across the mattress, legs dangling over the side. It's not an ideal position on Adora's small mattress, but she doesn't want to move Catra too much.

"I know," Adora whispers, running her fingers through Catra's hair in soothing, steady motions. Adora doesn't know the specifics, but that doesn't mean she can't understand. "You're safe here. I've got you." Catra is dragging in choked breaths, shaking harder as she presses closer to Adora. Soft hands reach out, drawing Catra's hand up to the center of Adora's chest, pressing it down flat so Catra can feel her inhales and exhales. She breathes slowly, in through her nose and careful exhales out through her mouth. She moves Catra's other hand so that she's feeling her own breath too, encouraging her to match Adora's rhythm.

It unnerves Catra, how easy it is to be soothed by Adora like this. They had shaped each other, taught each other what comfort looked like. As much as Catra has tried to twist herself into a different shape, she still fits with Adora. Her head spins, and she's not sure if it's from the fear flooding for her veins or from this dawning realization.

Minutes pass and Catra's breath grows incrementally more steady. She's still panting but she knows she's getting air now. Adora

keeps whispering gentle words, not really needing to be heard, just needing to assure Catra that she has someone with her that will look out for her. They both need to know their back is covered when they are hurting too much to keep themselves safe.

Adora doesn't have the blanket they grew up with here, but she pulls a plush one from the end of the bed and wraps it lightly around Catra. She wants her to feel held, not stifled. She encourages Catra to lie long ways on the bed, tucking pillows behind her. Catra's eyes fluttered closed at some point and she hasn't reopened them.

Adora sits up in the bed next to where she has Catra tucked in, pressing their sides together. She reaches out for her hand and squeezes tight. "Do you want to tell me?"

Catra swallows, raising her lids to look at Adora through slits. "Hordak. He's angry about the loss in Bright Moon. All my fault, apparently," she tells Adora bitterly, thinking about all of the failures she had no part in that were foisted upon her by Shadow Weaver. She is never good enough for anyone, maybe except for– well. Catra knows where hope gets her, and it's not anywhere good.

Adora blinks her eyes closed to center herself, to tame the anger flaring to life in her chest. She wants to tell Catra to stay, not to go back to whatever torturous punishment Hordak has conjured up. But Catra is here now. She came to Adora, trusting her to take care of her. Adora won't risk driving her away, not to beg her to come somewhere she already is, temporary as it may be.

Adora smiles wryly. "You did more damage than Hordak could've hoped to without your strategy. The war's been at a standstill for years. Things are moving now, and it's obvious that it's thanks to you. Not that I approve of your targets, but I admire your tactics even when I'm on the other side. Hordak doesn't know how lucky he is to have you there," *If only I were so lucky,* Adora thinks.

“He doesn’t seem to think so. I’m the only strategist worth a damn that the Horde’s ever had, and he’s there cowering in his sanctum and telling me I’ve never done anything right in my life.” Catra spits out bitterly.

Adora runs a hand down Catra’s arm soothingly. “That just shows what he’s worth, that’s not a reflection of you, Catra. When I got here, the Alliance was entirely dissolved and had been for ten years. They lost one big battle and every single one of the last generation of Princesses quit. Their only commander was Glimmer, who is my friend, but was also a reckless 18 year old with no military training. And Hordak was still losing against them!” Adora bursts out, her frustration at Bright Moon’s lack of strategy and precision coming out around the one person she knows will understand. Angella’s complete dismissal when Adora insisted that the Bright Moon guards needed to trade their ridiculous gowns for pants that would actually be practical for fighting still haunts her.

Catra snorts a wet laugh. Knowing Adora’s criticism didn’t extend only to the Horde, that she admired Catra’s strategy, still saw good in her, stitched something together inside of her.

“Bet he didn’t even know how weak their defense was. We didn’t have any kind of surveillance until Entrapta showed up. I think Hordak’s only great scientific contribution with all those years he spent in the lab was that weird little blue baby. I think I saw the *schematics* for it last time I was in the sanctum.”

Adora’s laughing now too. “What an influential contribution to the war effort.”

Their giggles fizzle out into the air and tension winds back into Catra’s shoulders. The pad of Adora’s thumb presses a tear away from Catra’s eye.

“But seriously, Catra. You have a united Princess Alliance fighting you, specifically because your strategy was so good that you would have obliterated the Rebellion as soon as you came to

power if things didn't change. You have way more might against you than he ever did, and you're still doing better than he was. He shouldn't be underestimating you. It'll be his own downfall."

All of that may have been true. Catra had seen first hand how ineffectual Hordak had been. But he could still hurt her. He might not be able to win a war, but what would it matter if he lost and Catra wasn't there to see it? She hadn't come here distraught like this because of a hurt ego. Her ego had been battered and bruised for years and she got out just fine, thank you very much. This was about survival. That was something Adora, with all her moralizing, had never fully understood.

"He's got a new toy. Sucks all the air out of a room in less than a second," Catra tells her, voice detached, to drive that point home.

Adora takes in a sharp breath. She knows Catra well enough to know Catra isn't bragging about one of his new weapons of destruction. She's seen it. Felt it. If Adora's whole life mission hadn't already been to take down the Horde, it would be now.

Adora holds her closer. She wishes for a moment that she had never left Catra alone there, but they both know that Adora had never been able to keep her safe in the Horde. They had a childhood's worth of memories to prove that.

Adora wants to tell Catra to come here, that there are places in this world where there will always be oxygen even if she has felt breathless for her entire life.

"I won't tell you twice. I know you don't even want to hear it once. But you'd be safe here, Catra. It doesn't have to be right here in this room but you have options."

Catra flips over in the bed, turning her back to Adora and nudging down deeper in the pillows and blankets. Adora worries she pushed too far, again, everytime, until Catra presses their bodies together again, twining her tail around Adora's forearm. She leaves her face buried in the fluff of bedding. All Adora can do is

tell her that she has a place here. Whether she'll take it is Catra's own choice.

Silence falls softly around them. Adora brings her hand up to pet Catra's ears and she feels a lump in her throat at getting to have this again, something she was sure Catra would never allow her to do again. The quiet rumble of Catra's purr fills the room.

Adora begins murmuring stories about Razz. She talks about how impressed Razz is with Catra's natural talent for making croissants, one of the most difficult things she had attempted to teach them. She chuckles as she tells Catra about the many batches Adora had attempted, all so disastrous that Razz dumped them without a second thought. She talks about her own memories of Catra's strategy as they were growing up, how she couldn't take her eyes off her during cadet tournaments. She describes masterful tactical decisions Catra made in battles, how Adora should've been focused on fighting and instead could only think of how brilliant Catra is. Adora reminds her that there are some people that she does not have to prove herself to.

When the darkness of night begins to lift, Adora feels cold, thinking of Catra gasping for breath. She fears whether Catra will have the chance to leave if she goes back tonight, but she does not move to stop Catra when she grapples out of the wind before dawn.

Chapter End Notes

Catra I love u and I'm so sorry :(

Thank you for reading! Final chapter with big emotional talks and lots of softness coming soon!

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The broad blades of silver shears push into a twisting mass of brambles, slicing through them and sending thorny vines tumbling to the ground. According to Razz, cutting the vines back like this will help it grow more fruit next season.

Razz had spent the last hour detailing the growing patterns of dewberries while Catra and Adora crowded around a pot of deep crimson jam, bubbling and staining the sides of the pot burgundy. It left thick drops as Catra stirred while relaying instructions to Adora, jutting out her elbows into Adora's side and snickering at her glares.

Now, clipped leaves flutter into Adora's splayed out hair where she is laid out in the grass beneath the arch. She's not moving a muscle to help with gardening today. Catra had handed her a pair of the weighty clippers when Adora arrived, and when her arms nearly buckled, she snatched them back and told Adora to lay down. As Adora sputtered and protested, a tail smacked her face and Catra advanced, poking her shoulders until Adora reluctantly laid down, pout firmly in place.

The fight the Rebellion got into earlier with the Horde had been brutal. The rest of the Alliance was out on a mission in the Kingdom of Snows, so it was only Bow, Glimmer and Adora. When they got there and surveyed the offense, Bow and Glimmer determined that She-Ra would be able to handle the tanks solo and the pair would go on reconnaissance to gather intel. There isn't an inch of her body where Adora can't feel the burn of laser turrets.

It is a relief not to hide it.

In the warm light of the afternoon and with Catra making jokes above her, the pout slips away along with the tension in her muscles.

“I really appreciate that Razz gives me so many sharp objects when I come here. You wouldn’t expect it from looking at her. She gets me.” Catra says contently, a smile quirking up the corner of her mouth. Only Catra would try to pitch gardening as something dangerous and badass, but Adora is sold as she watches the muscles in her arms shift and flex with each movement.

Adora is basking in the light and taking advantage of the unabashed opportunity to look at Catra when a berry catapults through the air and finds its target on her forehead. She blinks and looks at Catra smirking down at her. “Your fault for giving me such a big target, princess,” Catra teases.

There are a few stray berries left in the brambles, late in the season as it may be. Catra’s been throwing them at Adora every time she finds them; ostensibly to annoy her, but really Catra is just keeping her fed. Adora reaches for the berry and pops it into her mouth. “Thanks,” she grins up at Catra, knowing the most provoking option is to acknowledge that Catra is being nice to her. Catra rolls her eyes and turns her attention back to the task in front of her.

Vines continue to drop again as Catra focuses, leaving only the crimson red of the new growth behind. After several minutes, Catra stumbles upon another berry and carefully plucks it off among the thorns. Turning on her heel, Catra sees that Adora’s eyelids are drifting closed, raising slowly and infrequently.

“Falling asleep on me down there?” Catra asks, fondness shining in her tone.

Adora widens her eyes lazily, grinning up at Catra. “I would never,” she replies cheekily.

Catra shakes her head, popping the berry into her own mouth since she's the only one awake enough to appreciate it, whatever Adora says.

The shears thunk into the grass as Catra tosses them aside. She flops to the ground beside Adora, reaching over and gently plucking the leaves and thorny clippings out of the golden hair fanned across the underbrush. When she's ensured there's no chance of Adora impaling herself during her nap, Catra reclines and turns her eyes up to the arch she'd spent the afternoon on.

Catra allows her sore shoulders to melt as she drinks in the sight of the warm afternoon. A flutterglow flits around the pillar, alighting on the branches Catra was working near. Catra's irises are swallowed up as her pupils grow wide, tracking the movement of the bright creature.

Adora inches closer, pressing their sides together and pulling Catra's tail into her hands. She smooths her hands along it, comfort seeping into her bones. When the flutterglow leaves their line of sight, Catra turns towards Adora, nuzzling into her neck. Adora's breath begins to deepen, and Catra suspects she is drifting off. Catra relaxes further, resolving that they could both use the rest and knowing Adora would rouse if Catra moved.

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A thundering crash jolts Catra awake from her nap. She blinks, trying to orient herself to the sudden bright light and realizes Adora is already on her feet. Catra is up the next moment, claws snapped out and eyes darting around to assess the situation.

An elemental is crashing through the trees, barreling towards them. Weighty branches snap and plummet to the ground as it crushes everything in its wake, carving deep gashes into the dirt below.

The creature snaps its jaw, its thick carapace flashing blue as it writhes and catches the light streaming through the treetops. It

seems set on continuing its path through the clearing, but giant glassy eyes spot them and it changes course. Adora sees a glimpse of a pink crystal on its front as it hurtles towards them.

Catra and Adora take up fighting positions, but neither of them have weapons with them. Adora feels especially unprepared without the sword, but she never brings it when she sees Catra. She wouldn't want her to get the wrong idea about why Adora is coming. Shame lurches deep in her chest knowing she's put Catra in danger in this way.

The elemental lunges forward, diving into the ground beneath them, sending stone and chunks of earth erupting around them.

The ground beneath Adora's feet shutters, knocking her off balance. With her quicker reflexes, Catra rushes to lift her back up. The creature re-emerges and its mandible lashes against Catra as she pulls Adora up, not turning out of the way in time. Catra recoils, but she doesn't lose her footing as she hoists Adora to her feet.

"Catra!" Adora cries out helplessly, eyes wide with horror as she watches the creature swing against Catra. Adora is disappointing her again, failing her again. All Adora does is lead the people she loves into harm's way and then abandon them there. Catra has given her what she had hoped could have been a second chance, and this is how Adora repays her.

Desperately stirring every bit of emotion and energy left in her, Adora draws deep to the place where the runestones power resides within her. She's almost on empty, but she'd run on fumes for Catra. Blue ripples form across her skin in gaping patches and she yanks on them, urging them to envelope her. With a blinding flash, She-Ra thrusts herself between Catra and the elemental, diving forward and wrestling it to the ground.

It snaps and snarls against her as she fruitlessly knocks her newly materialized sword against its armored panels. She strikes too hard and the harsh reverberation makes her lose her grip. The

sword skitters onto the forest floor beneath them, gleaming blue just out of Adora's reach. She fumbles around, nails digging into the creature in desperate search of the crystal that she suspects is keeping it operational.

Her nails dig in beneath the beveled edge and she wrenches it free. The creature swings fiercely before it powers down, hurtling Adora upwards. She slams against the nearest tree and falls limp. She-Ra's form flickers as she falls, and Adora lies crumpled on the earth beneath.

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Hazy light flickers in and out of view as Adora's eyelids struggle to open. Adora is moving, but not under her own power. Her body is swaying and she's folded at her waist.

A moment later, she registers labored breathing. She catches a glimpse of Catra's arm swaying as she's jostled by the movement of Catra's quick gait. She is thrown over Catra's shoulder, the dense landscape of the woods blurring before her. Adora's head is throbbing and she can't understand how she got here.

She lets her eyes fall shut and slips back into unconsciousness, trusting Catra to take her wherever she needs to go.

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Adora wakes in the throne room in her usual chair, absolutely surrounded by neatly positioned plush purple and pink throw pillows. Adora thinks of the way Catra would precisely arrange their bunk when the lights went out at night. She blinks up at Catra who is close enough for Adora to see each of her freckles. She reaches a hand up and pushes Adora's loose hair out of her eyes. Catra's gaze is searching.

"Can I tell them?" Catra whispers. Adora lets her eyes fall shut and nods with a deflating exhale. She realizes as she allows her head to rest against the back of the chair that she lost her ponytail somewhere along the way. Adora glances up and sees

Glimmer sputtering at Catra's presence, but Bow just seems thoughtful. Catra turns on her heel, spinning around to face the other occupants of the room.

"So, you chucklefucks have basically been torturing Adora since she agreed to come play hero with you," Catra snarks at Bow and Glimmer.

"Catraaa," Adora whines at the brash delivery, but there's no real bite to her tone. She's still sleepy and a little disoriented, and she knows what Catra sounds like when she's really looking for a fight. This isn't it.

"We definitely have not been doing that. I don't know what exactly the Horde's been telling you about what we've been doing here, but it's clear from everything Adora's said that you didn't exactly get a fair representation of us there." Bow replies diplomatically, a little hurt seeping into his tone.

"Right, sure. Brainwashing, indoctrination, manipulation. We were child soldiers, I'm familiar with the concept. Do you really think that's the only way to hurt people, or that Shadow Weaver has a monopoly on those methods?"

"I think Hordak can do it too," Glimmer mutters under her breath. Catra rolls her eyes.

"Every hit Adora takes as She-Ra, she feels afterwards. I probably shouldn't be the one telling you this, but with the way things are going she's collapsing in the woods with only a murder-bug and her mortal enemy as witnesses, so something needs to change."

Silence rings in the room for a long moment. Only Adora's quickening breath interrupts it. Catra's at her side in a moment, stroking her hair. Jutting out her chin and squaring her shoulders, she pretends the twinkle twins can't see her being soft. Bow and Glimmer wait for Adora to object, to tell them it isn't true, but she doesn't raise her head, silently leaning into Catra's touch.

Bow and Glimmer exchange a devastated look as realization washes over their faces. They think of Adora dashing in front of them, taking hit after hit that would be deadly to any other member of the Rebellion. No one else tried to shield She-Ra, because she didn't need it, and they may have been putting themselves in more harms way than they could withstand. But Adora needed the same help and protection that she granted to everyone else without a second thought, and they haven't been giving that to her.

Adora keeps her eyes steadfastly on the tile floor, not glancing towards Bow and Glimmer on the other end of the table. She's afraid of what she'll see if she looks. She breathes in deep, reminding herself of the care Catra granted her when she confessed to this. She reminds herself of Glimmer reaching out to her, of Bow checking in on her. She still doesn't look up, but her breathing evens out.

"We, uh. Had a pretty big skirmish with Horde forces earlier today. Glimmer and I teleported to the center of operations for intel and Adora handled the fight," Bow reports grimly to Catra, not realizing it's the second time she's heard this recounted.

"That was reckless and callous. She's a person. Don't expect her to take hits you wouldn't take yourself," Catra replies flatly. "Look at her at the end of a battle and remember that it's there, even when you don't see it anymore. She'd battle a fucking army for you single handedly. This is a piss poor way to return the favor." Catra defends her vehemently, voice strengthening as she goes.

"Catra, I didn't tell them, they didn't…"

Catra's fingers twitch where they're pressed against Adora. "I know, princess. They didn't know, and now they know, and they're never going to fucking do it again." Her voice is sugar sweet and full of condescension. "Isn't that right?" She smiles at them, flashing her fangs.

Bow's eyes are watery as he sends soft looks at Adora across the table. "I'm so sorry, Adora. I thought we were being good friends, but actually we were being terrible friends!"

"It's not your fault," Adora assures him wetly, warmth flaring in her chest at Bow's acceptance. "I didn't tell you. I hid it. I didn't know if we could win the war without her. And - I didn't know if you would want me here if I was failing to use She-Ra's powers."

"We always want you here, Adora. You are more important to us than a fight. You're our friend." Bow assures her with conviction.

"I think one of you needs to put me out of misery after saying this, but Catra is right," Glimmer says with a grimace. Catra smirks and Adora swears she hears a faint trill from her direction. Glimmer continues, "I'm so sorry, Adora. We should've asked more questions, we should've known how it worked and made sure you were okay before we put you in that position. But we don't want you to be hurting, we never did. Things will be different now."

"We know that we can rely on you, Adora. You don't have to prove that to us. Let us show you that you can rely on us, too. Let us love you back," Bow requests softly.

Adora is crying in earnest now and Bow is by her side in a second, wrapping around her tightly and holding her grounded. Catra steps away quickly as he rushes over. "Best friend squad hug," he says, quieter than his usual overjoyed refrain. Glimmers on her feet in a second, holding them both close. Catra stands off to the side, arms linked behind her back, eyes downcast.

Bow extends a hand out to her, "That includes you too now, you know." She takes a tentative step forwards. Bow waits patiently, allowing her to approach at her own pace. Glimmer does not. She yanks Catra forward, crushing them all together and holding on tight. Adora might not be the only one crying anymore, but she's the only one that will admit to it after the fact.

Slowly, Adora begins to calm. She doesn't need the contact anymore, but she still wants it. Her tears are drying and she lets herself enjoy the moment.

She pulls back slightly to look down at Catra with a smirk, one eyebrow cocked high. "So. Mortal enemies, huh? Remind me, do mortal enemies tenderly carry you home to make sure you're taken care of?"

"Listen, if I have to stay here to make sure your reckless ass lives long enough to match me in a proper fight, that's not a reflection on me as a combatant."

"I'd never question you as a combatant," Adora replies, a huge grin overtaking her face.

"Damn right. So next time when you're on the verge of collapse, let someone else get some of the glory in the fight."

"I will," Adora promises. This time, she is confident that she will keep her promise.

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"This is my room," Adora nods to the doorway, tugging Catra inside by their linked hands.

"I've seen it before," Catra says with raised eyebrows. She almost makes it to a smirk, but the memory is too tinged with fear to quite get there.

"Yeah, but this is the first time you've come in through the door," Adora smiles softly. "You could stay here with me. You can talk to Glimmer about a guest room if you prefer, I guess." She draws to a halt, looks away, coughs. Then she raises her shoulders to her ears, tense but determined, and looks Catra in the eyes again. "But I'd like it if you stayed here with me."

"I'm not living in this stuffy palace," Catra replies, her nose wrinkling in distaste. "It stinks of magic here. You losers are going

to help me build a place in the Whispering Woods."

Adora swallows. She bites her tongue, but then she forces herself to ask the question. She's held back enough, and Catra is here now. "Is it just about not wanting to stay in the palace, or do you not want to stay with me?" Adora's face is pinched but she keeps her voice steady.

"I guess you can come with me," Catra tells her nonchalantly, "If you really want to," she says, some of the ease and levity leaving her voice.

Adora reaches for Catra's free hand so that they're linked by both hands and pulls Catra closer, pressing their foreheads together. "I really want to," she promises quietly.

Adora shifts back slightly, turning big puppy eyes onto Catra. "Will you stay with me here until it's built?"

Catra groans, "Fine. Fine! Stop looking at me like that," She pushes at Adora's face and Adora reels back laughing.

"This doesn't mean I'm joining your stupid Alliance. You'll be at enough of an advantage without having to go against my strategy anymore, so don't expect me to do anything else. I'm just going to bake pies in the woods with Razz forever."

"Sure, of course," Adora agrees easily, eyes sparkling. Catra will go stir crazy in less than a week and she'll be on the lookout for something more interesting to do. Even if she doesn't get bored, as soon as Catra sees how their tactical planning goes, she won't be able to stop herself from telling Glimmer how wrong she is and what they should be doing instead. Adora kind of can't wait to see how that goes. She's been waiting to see Catra slot into place here for so long.

"And there better not be any delays with the house!" Catra insists, "I'm not letting you scam me into getting infected with glitter by staying in this place too long."

“I’ve waited long enough to be here with you. I would go with you today if we could,” Adora’s sincerity pacifies Catra, and having put up the right amount of a fuss about it, she lets Adora draw her into the room without further protest.

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Progress on the house goes quickly. Angella easily approves the resource allocation, and Bow helps them pick a location with his knowledge of the woods. The first day that She-Ra stays until after sundown working on it, Catra prods Glimmer until she calls in more of their friends as backup.

Their friends arrive the next morning, with only a few pit stops as Glimmer misses their destination while teleporting.

“Ah, yes! The adventure of young love! I will be delighted to provide my prodigious building skills to this worthy task. I am well renowned across all of Salineas for my magnificent ship craftsmanship,” Sea Hawk boasts when he arrives.

Mermista approaches, propping her elbow on Sea Hawk’s shoulder and rolling her eyes.

“Yeahh, I bought you at least four of those boats. You’re better with destruction than construction.”

Catra snorts at Mermista’s bored tone, leaning into Adora’s space to whisper “I like her.”

Adora laughs, rolling her eyes, “Yeah, I thought you might.”

Catra cries laughing when Adora beats Sea Hawk in arm wrestling in 10 seconds flat at lunch that day. Catra mocks him ruthlessly and is secretly amused by him, allowing his presence around her home as long as Mermista always stays by his side to make sure nothing catches on fire.

Swiftwind totes all their supplies back and forth so Adora doesn’t feel the need to do it herself. “Adora and Catra and Swift Wind,

building a house!” He sings as he swoops down into the clearing with his latest haul.

Catra grits her teeth. She genuinely kind of hates this thing, but she’s not surprised Adora is obsessed with it. She would always make up stories about the beasts they saw roaming at the edges of Horde territory when they were kids, and Adora always made them sound friendlier and cuddlier than the shadowy figures looked to Catra. It’s kind of sweet to see those stories fulfilled, so she swallows her distaste. Mostly.

Perfuma comes to help Catra get her garden set up. There are twisting vines of passion flowers climbing up the columns of the house as if they’ve already lived there for years. The berry patches in the back, also boosted with Perfuma’s magic, will have fruit to make enough jam to go around their very first summer. Perfuma's relentlessly cheerful attitude is insufferable, but as long as they’re only talking about plants, Catra can tolerate her.

Netossa and Spinerella hoist a lot of the heavier supplies that need to go higher up, getting most of the roof in place with glowing nets to lift them up and swirling winds to slot each piece into place. Adora doesn’t even mind the smug looks Netossa keeps shooting them. Adora just beams back, arm wrapped firmly around Catra. Spinerella pulls them aside to offer them soft congratulations, and Netossa just laughs at them. Catra sticks close to them at the beginning, when having so many people around sets her on edge.

“Netossa came and talked to me,” Catra confesses to Adora when they are back in their bedroom in the palace after a long day of work, Catra cuddled in Adora’s arms in the bigger and plusher bed that was a compromise that Catra insisted on between Adora’s Horde style twin bed and the decadent mass typical to Bright Moon.

“When, today?” Adora questions, not following this impromptu line of conversation.

“No, before. She found me in the Whispering Woods after you talked to her about me. She asked if winning Hordak’s war was the most important thing to me. Told me I might need to think about what I wanted, too.”

Realization washes across Adora’s face, and she runs her hands up and down Catra’s arms to steady herself and try to process this new information. “That’s why you were mad at me for talking to people about you?”

“Yeah. I was half convinced you sent her after me at the start.”

“I would never,” Adora professes, furrow in her brow.

“I know that now, Adora,” Catra assures her, tone fond and exasperated. She raises a hand to smooth out the crease on her forehead.

“So, what did you tell her? What did you say you wanted?”

“Fishing for compliments, princess?” Catra tilts her head to smirk up at her.

“What? No!” Adora blusters a little, face turning red in contradiction. “Not unless you want to.”

Catra laughs at her. “I told her the war was the most important thing to me and that I would never listen to her stupid advice.”

Adora raises an eyebrow at Catra, squeezing her arms around her briefly. “Oh, yeah? You stand by that?”

“Pft. Obviously.”

Adora gasps in mock offense. “And there I was, telling Netossa about how all I wanted was for you to be happy and telling Razz about how much I missed you.” Catra pretends that Adora can’t notice the hitch in her breath and widening of her pupils when she hears that. She knows now that Adora never stopped caring about her, even at their worst, but these reminders always help.

“Wow, you must really like me, princess. That’s so embarrassing for you,” Catra smirks.

Adora presses their cheeks together, nuzzling in. “You moved into a pink sparkly palace for me, so I think we might be even.”

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As the sun sets on the day they put the final touches on the house, Adora feels like she can see their whole life playing out around her, when the war is over and they get to be at peace together.

She sees Spinerella and Netossa on their well-worn corduroy couch, a board game sprawling on the table in front of them. Catra places her last piece triumphantly, looking up at Netossa with a wicked grin. Adora whoops and pumps her fist, pulling Catra into her and kissing the side of her head. Netossa flips the board and Catra laughs so hard that there are tears in her eyes as she pelts Netossa with game pieces and boos. Spinerella fends off the attacks on her wife with gusts of wind, patting Netossa’s knee in comfort and holding back a laugh of her own.

Casta and Juliet come by to drop off Winterfest presents when the ground is dusted with snow and the chimney is puffing out smoke. Adora pulls out chairs for them around their scuffed round wooden table and places cups of tea for them on the floral tablecloth from Razz.

They tell stories from Mystacor, and Juliet conspiratorily leans in to tell Catra about the many times Adora’s antics had her chased or barred from rooms by the Brightmoon Guard. Adora defends herself every time and insists that guards in an active war zone shouldn’t be wearing flowing robes. Catra disagrees, even though Adora can tell from her expression that she’s just doing it to be contrarian. The couple leaves well after sunset with clipped flowers from the garden.

For the rest of winter, Catra pretends to complain about the sweater Casta knit her, but she hardly takes it off for weeks. She says it's just too cold when she's outside in the woods, but she still wears it when she's cuddled up by the fireplace.

Razz comes over and spends hours in the kitchen with them, teaching Catra new recipes and trying to help Adora through the basics. Catra is working the dough for a complicated Eternian pastry that was one of Mara's favorites. Powdered sugar has puffed onto her cheek and across the apron Bow made for her. She looks up from her work to Adora, eyes bright, and says encouraging words about the simple icing Adora is working on with only the hint of a smirk. It doesn't matter if Adora masters her recipe, because Catra and Razz always swoop in to fix her mistakes and share their own creations.

Adora breathes in the cool evening air, admiring all of the signs that their home is ready for them. The chimney is puffing smoke, the one sanctioned fire Sea Hawk was allowed to set, warming up their home for them. There's a carefully arranged basket of Brightmoon's finest food that Bow packed for the night. Looking around, she realizes that all of their friends have left for the night.

Warm streaks of gold and orange filter through the trees as the day moons set, illuminating the tenderly cared for flowers lining the house. Sturdy wooden beams support the large front porch. On a beam just to the side of the entrance, all of their friends have left their mark. It had started with Sea Hawk carving a flaming heart as he sang a shanty about love, and then Bow and Glimmer adding their signature heart and moon. Catra had grumbled about them 'defiling her home,' but Adora saw her carve in their little childhood drawing of themselves when she thought no one was looking. Stepping forward, Adora's fingertips gently trace the marks left by the people that love them.

Adora doesn't realize she's crying until she feels Catra reach out and wipe a tear away, bringing her back to the present.

Intertwining their hands, she tugs Adora into the doorway and up to their room.

“Come on, Adora. It’s time to rest now.”

Chapter End Notes

> And we are done!! Thank you all so much for reading!! Reminder that there is an accompanying playlist for this fic if you're interested here.
>
> Shoutout to firelikestars for writing the beautiful birthday fic that inspired this and for betaing and talking through ideas with me this whole time. Love u so much!! If you are into Good Omens, pls go check out their fics!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!